A small beginning, a great miracle

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

נעשה בו נס והדליקו ממנו שמונה ימים

A miracle occurred with it, and they lit from it for eight days.

Shabbat 21b | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Gemara tells us that after the Chashmonaim defeated their enemies, they found only one container of oil bearing the Kohen Gadol's seal. It held enough for one day, yet it supplied eight days of light. Chanukah remembers Hashem's help and the return to serving Him in the Beit HaMikdash. Our family learning is also a small beginning: ten minutes in which we make room for Torah and for one another.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Tonight is Friday. Light Chanukah candles before Shabbat candles, before Shabbat begins. Prepare enough oil or long-lasting candles to burn until at least half an hour after nightfall. An adult should check local times. Print this sheet beforehand; discuss and answer aloud on Shabbat.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Tell the Chanukah story in three turns: the difficulty, the discovery, and the miracle. Each partner adds one part. Then each person names one thing that makes learning together enjoyable.

Younger learners: Hold up one finger, then eight. What changed?
Older learners: Why does the seal matter? How is remembering a miracle different from expecting a miracle to solve our problems?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. How many days could the oil naturally last? 2. How many days did it actually supply light?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Read the selections from Rambam 3:1-3 on the reverse. He describes both rescue from oppression and the oil. Explain how these two parts belong to the same celebration.

Sources: Shabbat 21b; Friday lighting: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1; Mishnah Berurah 679:2; Rambam 3:1-3.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Shabbat 21b | The oil miracle

Selected passage

שכשנכנסו יוונים להיכל טמאו כל השמנים שבהיכל וכשגברה מלכות בית חשמונאי ונצחום בדקו ולא מצאו אלא פך אחד של שמן שהיה מונח בחותמו של כהן גדול ולא היה בו אלא להדליק יום אחד נעשה בו נס והדליקו ממנו שמונה ימים לשנה אחרת קבעום ועשאום ימים טובים בהלל והודאה

When the Greeks entered the Sanctuary, they made all its oil impure. When the Chashmonaim overcame and defeated them, they searched and found only one container of oil bearing the Kohen Gadol's seal. It held enough to light for only one day. A miracle occurred, and they lit from it for eight days. The following year, they established these as festive days of praise and thanksgiving.

2. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:1-3 | Selections

Excerpts from 3:1, 3:2 and 3:3, in order; omissions marked

ולא הניחו אותם לעסוק בתורה ובמצוות ... עד שריחם עליהם אלהי אבותינו, והושיעם מידם והצילם ... ולא מצאו שמן טהור במקדש אלא פך אחד ולא היה בו להדליק אלא יום אחד בלבד והדליקו ממנו נרות המערכה שמונה ימים ... ומפני זה התקינו חכמים שבאותו הדור שיהיו שמונת ימים האלו שתחלתן כ"ה בכסליו ימי שמחה והלל

They did not allow them to study Torah and observe mitzvot ... until the God of our ancestors had mercy on them, saved them from their hands, and rescued them ... They found only one container of pure oil in the Temple, enough for just one day, and used it to light the lamps for eight days ... Therefore, the Sages of that generation established these eight days, beginning on 25 Kislev, as days of joy and praise.

3. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1 | Friday lighting

Selected passage

בערב שבת מדליקין נר חנוכה תחלה ואחר כך נר שבת.

On Friday afternoon, one lights the Chanukah lamp first, and afterward the Shabbat lamp.

4. Mishnah Berurah 679:2 | Enough fuel

Selected passage

וכבר כתבנו בשם האחרונים דצריך ליתן בה שמן עד שידלק חצי שעה אחר צאת הכוכבים וכן במדליק נרות

We have already written in the name of the later authorities that one must put in enough oil for it to burn until half an hour after nightfall. The same applies when lighting candles.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Compare the two miracles described by Rambam: rescue from oppression and the oil. Which words express our response? The selections above supply the passages needed for the front-side extension.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

One more light, one more step

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

מעלין בקדש ואין מורידין

We rise in holiness and do not descend.

Shabbat 21b | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Beit Shammai and Beit Hillel discuss different ways to count the lights. Beit Hillel begins with one and adds each night; this is our practice. One explanation in the Gemara connects this to rising in holiness. Family connection: progress can happen in small steps. Yesterday's learning matters, and tonight we have another chance to grow. Missing a session does not stop you from joining again.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Tonight is Saturday night. Wait until Shabbat has ended before lighting or using a device. Customs differ about the order of Havdalah and Chanukah lighting at home; follow your family's practice. Tonight has two mitzvah lights, plus a separate shamash.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Take turns proposing one small, realistic addition to your learning or kindness this week. Choose one together. Say when you will do it and who will help.

Younger learners: How many mitzvah lights will we light tomorrow?
Older learners: Why might increasing the lights express something different from lighting eight every night?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Do we add or remove a light each night? 2. Does the shamash count as one of tonight's two mitzvah lights?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

In Shabbat 21b, compare counting the days still to come with counting the days already reached. Give the strongest explanation you can for each position before explaining our practice.

Sources: Shabbat 21b; Saturday night: Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 681:2.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Shabbat 21b | Two ways to count

Excerpt with an omission marked

והמהדרין מן המהדרין ב"ש אומרים יום ראשון מדליק שמנה מכאן ואילך פוחת והולך וב"ה אומרים יום ראשון מדליק אחת מכאן ואילך מוסיף והולך ... חד אמר טעמא דב"ש כנגד ימים הנכנסין וטעמא דב"ה כנגד ימים היוצאין וחד אמר טעמא דב"ש כנגד פרי החג וטעמא דבית הלל דמעלין בקדש ואין מורידין

For those who beautify the mitzvah most: Beit Shammai say to light eight on the first day and then decrease; Beit Hillel say to light one on the first day and then increase ... One explanation is that Beit Shammai count the days still to come, and Beit Hillel count the days already reached. Another connects Beit Shammai to the decreasing number of bulls offered on Sukkot, and Beit Hillel to the principle that we rise in holiness and do not descend.

2. Shulchan Aruch & Rema, O.C. 681:2 | One practice

Selected passage

מדליקין נר חנוכה בבהכ"נ קודם ההבדלה. הגה: וכ"ש בביתו שמדליק ואח"כ מבדיל שהרי כבר הבדיל בבהכ"נ.

In the synagogue, the Chanukah lamp is lit before Havdalah. Rema: All the more so at home, one lights and then recites Havdalah, since one has already recited Havdalah in the synagogue.

3. Taz on O.C. 681:2 | Another practice, concluding words

Selected passage

ראוי לו להבדיל בביתו ברישא והדר להדליק נ"ח

It is appropriate for him to recite Havdalah at home first, and afterward light the Chanukah lamp.

4. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1 | A separate light

Excerpt with an omission marked

ונוהגים להדליק נר נוסף כדי שאם ישתמש לאורה יהיה לאור הנוסף ... ויניחנו מרחוק קצת משאר נרות מצוה

The custom is to light an additional lamp so that, if one uses the light, it will be the light of the additional lamp ... One places it a little apart from the other mitzvah lights.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

These passages record differing practices. Follow your family's custom at home. All lighting is after Shabbat ends. In the Gemara, identify one reason based on counting and one based on holiness.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

Our home, our minhag

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

נר איש וביתו

A light for a person and their household.

Shabbat 21b | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Chanukah brings the mitzvah into the home. Rabbi Yosef Karo's Shulchan Aruch describes one set of lights that increases each night for the household. Rabbi Moshe Isserles, the Rema, records the Ashkenazic practice of individual household members lighting. Sephardic families generally follow the household practice; many Ashkenazic families have several members light. Each family follows its minhag. Different practices can express a shared love of the same mitzvah.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Women and men are obligated in Chanukah lighting. A woman can light for the household. Children learn to participate according to their family's custom and with adult supervision. Helping prepare or singing together also gives children a meaningful role.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Ask a partner: Who lit when you were little? Where did you gather? Which song do you remember? If no one remembers, choose a song or learning routine your family can begin now.

Younger learners: Name one way you can help your family celebrate.
Older learners: How can we explain another family's minhag respectfully, even when it differs from ours?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Are women obligated in Chanukah lighting? 2. Do all Jewish families follow exactly the same household-lighting practice?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Compare Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 671:2. The Rema also discusses keeping people's lights in distinct places. Why does being able to recognize each set matter?

Sources: Shabbat 21b; Household customs: Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 671:2; Women: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 675:3.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Shabbat 21b | A household mitzvah

Selected passage

ת"ר מצות חנוכה נר איש וביתו והמהדרין נר לכל אחד ואחד

The Sages taught: The Chanukah mitzvah is a lamp for a person and their household. Those who beautify the mitzvah have a lamp for each person.

2. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 671:2 | Household lighting

Selected passage

כמה נרות מדליק? בלילה הראשון מדליק אחד, מכאן ואילך מוסיף והולך אחד בכל לילה, עד שבליל אחרון יהיו שמונה. ואפילו אם רבים בני הבית לא ידליקו יותר.

How many lamps does one light? On the first night, one; afterward, one adds a lamp each night, until there are eight on the last night. Even if there are many household members, they do not light more.

3. Rema on O.C. 671:2 | Individual lighting

Parenthetical source citations omitted

ויש אומרים דכל אחד מבני הבית ידליק ... וכן המנהג פשוט. ויזהרו לתן כל אחד ואחד נרותיו במקום מיוחד כדי שיהא היכר כמה נרות מדליקין

Some say that each household member should light ... and this is the widespread custom. Each person should be careful to put their lamps in a distinct place, so that the number being lit can be recognized.

4. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 675:3; Magen Avraham 675:4

Opening words of the ruling and opening explanation

אשה מדלקת נר חנוכה שאף היא חייבת בה

מגן אברהם: פי' בעד כל בני הבית

A woman lights the Chanukah lamp, for she too is obligated in it. Magen Avraham explains: This means on behalf of all the household members.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

The first two rulings describe different ways to beautify the same mitzvah. Explain why distinct places help identify the number of lights.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

Lights that tell a story

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

להראות ולגלות הנס

To show and make the miracle known.

Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:3 | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Rambam explains that we light at the entrances of our homes to make the miracle known. This idea is called pirsumei nisa: publicizing the miracle. The light points beyond itself to something worth remembering. Family connection: when someone asks about our Chanukiah, we have a chance to explain why it matters to us, in words they can understand.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

The Gemara describes lighting by an outside entrance, or a window facing the public way for someone living upstairs; in danger, indoors is sufficient. Actual placement depends on the home and family practice. Use a safe, stable location chosen by an adult. Never move a burning Chanukiah for an activity.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Pretend a friendly visitor has never seen a Chanukiah. One partner asks about it; the other explains the oil miracle and why we light. Switch roles. Keep each explanation under one minute.

Younger learners: Point to the shamash from a safe distance. What makes it different?
Older learners: Why might the place of a mitzvah help communicate its meaning? What changes when public display is unsafe?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. What does pirsumei nisa mean? 2. In danger, must someone insist on lighting outside?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Compare Shabbat 21b with Rambam 3:3. Identify the purpose and the possible locations. Explain how a mitzvah can keep its purpose while its practical setting changes.

Sources: Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:3; Placement and danger: Shabbat 21b.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:3

Selected passage

ומפני זה התקינו חכמים שבאותו הדור שיהיו שמונת ימים האלו שתחלתן כ"ה בכסליו ימי שמחה והלל ומדליקין בהן הנרות בערב על פתחי הבתים בכל לילה ולילה משמונת הלילות להראות ולגלות הנס.

Therefore, the Sages of that generation established these eight days, beginning on 25 Kislev, as days of joy and praise. On each of the eight nights, lamps are lit in the evening at the entrances of homes, to show and make the miracle known.

2. Shabbat 21b | Place and circumstances

Selected passage

ת"ר נר חנוכה מצוה להניחה על פתח ביתו מבחוץ אם היה דר בעלייה מניחה בחלון הסמוכה לרה"ר ובשעת הסכנה מניחה על שלחנו ודיו

The Sages taught: It is a mitzvah to place the Chanukah lamp outside the entrance to one's home. Someone living upstairs places it at a window facing the public area. In a time of danger, placing it on one's table is sufficient.

3. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:9 | Lighting in place

Selected passage

הדליקו מבפנים והוציאו דלוק והניחו על פתח ביתו לא עשה כלום עד שידליקנו במקומו

If one lit it inside, carried it outside while burning, and placed it at the entrance, one has not fulfilled the mitzvah; it must be lit in its proper place.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Find the purpose in Rambam and the possible locations in the Gemara. Why is lighting in the proper place part of communicating the mitzvah?

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

Seeing Hashem in the ordinary

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

מי שאמר לשמן וידלוק

The One who told oil to burn...

Taanit 25a, opening words of Rabbi Chanina's response | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Gemara tells a story about Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa and his daughter. Before Shabbat, she was upset: she had mistakenly used vinegar in her lamp instead of oil. Her father reassured her that the One who makes oil burn could also make vinegar burn. The Gemara reports that the lamp continued burning through Shabbat, until they used its flame for Havdalah. This is a Shabbat story, not a Chanukah event. It invites us to notice Hashem's gifts in ordinary life as well as in miracles.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Chanukah lights are for the mitzvah, not for lighting our reading or other tasks. Use normal room lighting to read this sheet. The shamash is separate from the mitzvah lights. The story is not an experiment: do not try burning vinegar or changing a lamp's fuel.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Each partner names one everyday gift they sometimes overlook. Explain what life would be like without it. Then thank Hashem in your own words for one of those gifts.

Younger learners: Name something your body can do that you are thankful for.
Older learners: If ordinary nature comes from Hashem, what makes an unusual miracle especially noticeable?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Did Rabbi Chanina's daughter mistakenly use vinegar or water? 2. May we use the mitzvah lights as our reading light?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Reread Rabbi Chanina's response in Taanit 25a. Separate the event the Gemara reports from the lesson we draw. Does gratitude for Hashem's help remove our responsibility to prepare carefully? Explain.

Sources: Taanit 25a, opening words of Rabbi Chanina's response; Use of light: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Taanit 25a | Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa and his daughter

Complete story passage; a Shabbat event, not a Chanukah event

חד בי שמשי חזייה לברתיה דהוות עציבא אמר לה בתי למאי עציבת אמרה ליה כלי של חומץ נתחלף לי בכלי של שמן והדלקתי ממנו אור לשבת אמר לה בתי מאי איכפת לך מי שאמר לשמן וידלוק הוא יאמר לחומץ וידלוק תנא היה דולק והולך כל היום כולו עד שהביאו ממנו אור להבדלה

One Friday evening, he saw that his daughter was sad. He asked, "My daughter, why are you sad?" She answered, "I confused a container of vinegar with a container of oil, and lit the Shabbat lamp from it." He said, "My daughter, why should that trouble you? The One who told oil to burn will tell vinegar to burn." It was taught: It continued burning throughout the day, until they took a flame from it for Havdalah.

2. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1 | Using the light

Selected passage

לפי שאסור להשתמש בנר חנוכה בין בשבת בין בחול ואפילו לבדוק מעות או למנותן לאורה אסור ואפילו תשמיש של קדושה כגון ללמוד לאורה אסור ויש מי שמתיר בתשמיש של קדושה.

It is forbidden to use the Chanukah light, whether on Shabbat or a weekday. Even inspecting or counting coins by its light is forbidden. Even a sacred use, such as studying by its light, is forbidden; there is an opinion that permits a sacred use.

3. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 673:1 | The additional lamp

Selected passage

ונוהגים להדליק נר נוסף כדי שאם ישתמש לאורה יהיה לאור הנוסף שהוא אותו שהודלק אחרון ויניחנו מרחוק קצת משאר נרות מצוה.

The custom is to light an additional lamp, so that if one uses the light, it will be the light of that additional lamp, which was lit last. One places it a little apart from the other mitzvah lamps.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Our practice is to use normal room light for study, as on the front. The source records another opinion; its presence is a chance to notice how halachic texts preserve discussion. This miracle story is not an instruction to experiment with fire.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

Thankfulness we can put into words

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

להודות ולהלל לשמך הגדול

To thank and praise Your great name.

Al HaNissim for Chanukah, concluding words | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Al HaNissim tells of Hashem helping the Jewish people when they faced powerful enemies. It remembers their return to the Beit HaMikdash and ends with thanks and praise. Chanukah is more than receiving gifts or eating a favorite food: we practice noticing, remembering, and thanking. Family connection: a specific thank-you shows that we noticed what someone actually did.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

We add Al HaNissim in the Amidah and Birkat HaMazon. If it was forgotten, we do not repeat the entire prayer or Birkat HaMazon just for that omission. Ask an adult to help you find its place in the siddur or birkon your family uses.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Find Al HaNissim together, then each give a specific thank-you to another person: name what they did and how it helped. Finish by naming one thing for which your family thanks Hashem.

Younger learners: Finish: Thank you for helping me with...
Older learners: What is the difference between thanking someone for help and praising a quality they showed?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Name one prayer in which we add Al HaNissim. 2. Must we repeat the whole prayer just because we forgot Al HaNissim?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Read the Chanukah paragraph of Al HaNissim on the reverse. Find a phrase about the struggle, a phrase about Hashem's help, and a phrase about the people's response. Explain why the prayer includes all three.

Sources: Al HaNissim for Chanukah, concluding words; Al HaNissim and omissions: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 682:1.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Al HaNissim | Chanukah paragraph

Chanukah paragraph, one printed nusach; family siddur wording may differ

בימי מתתיהו בן יוחנן כהן גדול חשמונאי ובניו, כשעמדה מלכות יון הרשעה על עמך ישראל להשכיחם תורתך ולהעבירם מחקי רצונך, ואתה ברחמיך הרבים עמדת להם בעת צרתם, רבת את ריבם, דנת את דינם, נקמת את נקמתם, מסרת גבורים ביד חלשים, ורבים ביד מעטים, וטמאים ביד טהורים, ורשעים ביד צדיקים, וזדים ביד עוסקי תורתך, ולך עשית שם גדול וקדוש בעולמך, ולעמך ישראל עשית תשועה גדולה ופרקן כהיום הזה. ואחר כך באו בניך לדביר ביתך, ופנו את היכלך, וטהרו את מקדשך, והדליקו נרות בחצרות קדשך, וקבעו שמונת ימי חנכה אלו, להודות ולהלל לשמך הגדול.

In the days of Mattityahu son of Yochanan, the Kohen Gadol, the Chashmonai, and his sons, the wicked Greek kingdom rose against Your people Israel to make them forget Your Torah and turn them away from the laws of Your will. In Your great mercy, You stood by them in their distress. You fought their struggle, judged their case, and avenged them. You delivered the strong into the hands of the weak, the many into the hands of the few, the impure into the hands of the pure, the wicked into the hands of the righteous, and the arrogant into the hands of those who study Your Torah. You made Yourself a great and holy name in Your world, and brought Your people Israel great salvation and deliverance, as on this day. Afterward, Your children entered the inner chamber of Your House, cleared Your Sanctuary, purified Your Temple, and lit lamps in Your holy courtyards. They established these eight days of Chanukah to thank and praise Your great name.

2. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 682:1 | Where it belongs

Opening sentences; later details about remembering mid-blessing omitted

כל שמונת ימי חנוכה אומר על הנסים בברכת המזון בברכת הארץ ובתפלה בברכת מודים. ואם לא אמר אין מחזירין אותו.

On all eight days of Chanukah, one says Al HaNissim in Birkat HaMazon, in the blessing for the land, and in the Amidah, in the blessing of thanksgiving. If one did not say it, one does not repeat.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Find a phrase about the struggle, a phrase about Hashem's help, and a phrase about the people's response. Use your own siddur's nusach when praying.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

Rav Mordechai Eliyahu: a light that lasts

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

נר מצוה ותורה אור

A mitzvah is a lamp, and Torah is light.

Mishlei 6:23 | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Rav Shmuel Eliyahu relates that he met a woman at Me'arat HaMachpelah who told him about attending Chanukah lighting with his father, Rav Mordechai Eliyahu. The experience moved her to want a home filled with Torah and joy. She began attending Torah classes and became more careful with berachot and tefillah. Years later, she still remembered that lighting as a turning point. This is an abridged retelling of her recollection, published in Avihem Shel Yisrael, volume 11, and on the Rav's memorial website. Its message for us: an inspiring moment can lead to a lasting practice.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

The shamash does not count toward the night's mitzvah lights. Tonight there are seven mitzvah lights plus the shamash. Keep it visibly separate, following your family's Chanukiah arrangement.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Each person chooses one small practice to continue after Chanukah: a berachah said thoughtfully, a short Torah conversation, or a regular act of kindness. Tell your partner when you will do it. Partners help each other choose something realistic.

Younger learners: Which good practice would you like to do again tomorrow?
Older learners: Which details in the account show a change in actions, rather than only a strong feeling?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Whose Chanukah lighting did the woman attend? 2. Name one practice she strengthened afterward.

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Read Mishlei 6:23 and the story again. Which image in the verse helps explain the story? Label your connection as an interpretation, not something the woman or Rav explicitly said.

Sources: Mishlei 6:23; Story: Avihem Shel Yisrael, vol. 11; account related by Rav Shmuel Eliyahu; Separate shamash: Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 673:1.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Mishlei 6:23 | A lamp and a light

Complete verse, without cantillation or vowel marks

כי נר מצוה ותורה אור ודרך חיים תוכחות מוסר.

For a mitzvah is a lamp, and Torah is light; corrective instruction is the way of life.

2. Rashi on Mishlei 6:23 | Torah that stays with us

Opening explanation

כמו שהאור מאיר לעולם תמיד כך התורה עומדת זכותה לעולם אל האדם וזכות מצוה לפי שעה כאור הנר

Just as light continually illuminates the world, the merit of Torah remains with a person forever; the merit of a mitzvah is for its moment, like the light of a lamp.

3. Avihem Shel Yisrael, vol. 11 | Published story excerpt

Brief verbatim excerpt from the account related by Rav Shmuel Eliyahu; the front contains an abridged retelling

היא התחילה לשמוע שיעורי תורה

She began attending Torah classes.

4. Shulchan Aruch & Rema, O.C. 673:1 | Distinct shamash

Excerpts; intervening text omitted

ויניחנו מרחוק קצת משאר נרות מצוה ... הגה: ובמדינות אלו אין נוהגים להוסיף רק מניח אצלן השמש שבו מדליק הנרות והוא עדיף טפי ויש לעשותו יותר ארוך משאר נרות שאם בא להשתמש ישתמש לאותו נר.

One places the additional lamp a little apart from the other mitzvah lamps ... Rema: In these lands, the custom is not to add another lamp, but to place beside them the shamash used for lighting; this is preferable. It should be longer than the other lamps so that, if one uses the light, one uses that lamp.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Read the front-side story alongside Mishlei and Rashi. Which action shows that inspiration continued afterward? Connecting this story to the verse is our learning exercise, not a quotation from Rav Mordechai Eliyahu.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.

The brightest home is a peaceful home

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

גדול השלום

Great is peace.

Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:14 | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Rambam considers a person who can afford either a Shabbat lamp or a Chanukah lamp, but not both. The Shabbat lamp takes priority because light in the home supports peace. He ends by teaching the greatness of peace and the Torah's peaceful ways. Family connection: the way we speak while doing a mitzvah matters. After eight nights, our success includes what we learned and how we treated our learning partners.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Tonight is Friday again: light Chanukah candles before Shabbat candles, before Shabbat begins, with enough fuel to last at least half an hour after nightfall. There are eight mitzvah lights plus the shamash. Print before Shabbat; save online logging until afterward.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Each person shares one idea they remember, thanks a learning partner, and names one way to make home more peaceful. Agree on a ten-minute family learning time for the coming week. On Shabbat, make this plan aloud.

Younger learners: What can you say when two people want the same turn?
Older learners: Why would the Rambam finish the laws of Chanukah with peace? How can a religious activity support peace in practice?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. In the Rambam's either-or case, which lamp takes priority? 2. What reason does he give?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Compare Rambam 4:12, which stresses how precious Chanukah lighting is, with 4:14, which prioritizes peace in the home. Explain why a precious mitzvah can still have another mitzvah take priority in a specific case.

Sources: Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:14; Friday lighting: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1; Mishnah Berurah 679:2; Precious mitzvah and peace: Rambam 4:12-14.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:12

Opening sentence

מצות נר חנוכה מצוה חביבה היא עד מאד וצריך אדם להזהר בה כדי להודיע הנס ולהוסיף בשבח האל והודיה לו על הנסים שעשה לנו.

The mitzvah of the Chanukah lamp is exceedingly precious. One must take care with it, to make the miracle known and to increase praise of God and thanks to Him for the miracles He performed for us.

2. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:14

Complete halacha; the home lamp here is the Shabbat lamp

היה לפניו נר ביתו ונר חנוכה או נר ביתו וקדוש היום נר ביתו קודם משום שלום ביתו שהרי השם נמחק לעשות שלום בין איש לאשתו. גדול השלום שכל התורה ניתנה לעשות שלום בעולם שנאמר דרכיה דרכי נעם וכל נתיבותיה שלום

If one must choose between a lamp for the home and a Chanukah lamp, or between a lamp for the home and Kiddush, the home lamp takes priority, because of peace in the home. For even the Divine Name is erased to bring peace between husband and wife. Great is peace: the entire Torah was given to make peace in the world, as it says, "Her ways are pleasant ways, and all her paths are peace."

3. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 679:1 | Friday lighting

Selected passage

בערב שבת מדליקין נר חנוכה תחלה ואחר כך נר שבת.

On Friday afternoon, one lights the Chanukah lamp first, and afterward the Shabbat lamp.

4. Mishnah Berurah 679:2 | Enough fuel

Selected passage

וכבר כתבנו בשם האחרונים דצריך ליתן בה שמן עד שידלק חצי שעה אחר צאת הכוכבים וכן במדליק נרות

We have already written in the name of the later authorities that one must put in enough oil for it to burn until half an hour after nightfall. The same applies when lighting candles.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

The reference to erasing the Divine Name concerns the Torah's sotah procedure. For this learning, focus on the stated value: peace. Why does prioritizing Shabbat light not make Chanukah lighting unimportant?

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.